



SKOAR!

Is social gaming a waste of time or is it the next best thing in gaming? **SKOAR's** own "Psycho Mantis" and "Big Daddy" debate over the issue.

SOCIAL GAMING: A NUISANCE?

YES – IT'S A NUISANCE!

When you hear the word social gaming, the first thing that comes to mind is Farmville. Social networking sites like Facebook and Google Plus are full of mindless games like CityVille, Poker, Pool, Bubble Island, so on and so forth. These games consume your bandwidth, keep you hooked to a computer screen and encourage you to waste real money on buying things that don't really exist.

The biggest reason why social gaming is useless is that the games lack depth. You pick up one activity and just stick to it. Every second game you play feels just like the last one with different colors and objects. There is no story, no real action, and no motive to keep on going and definitely no feeling of success once you've accomplished your goal. Just plant another batch of cabbage.

Since its inception, gaming has always been about getting a high score and beating your friends. Even today, games like Call of Duty, Uncharted, Halo and more, all have a stellar story, gripping gameplay and online features where you

can take on your friend's head to head to prove who is the king of the hill. In social gaming, all you can do is send requests to your friends to come and grow carrots with you! What's the purpose of that? What happened to the adrenaline rush from winning by that nanosecond?

Even in the same genre, every social game feels the same. In traditional gaming, every game feels different – for e.g. racing. You may master NFS but struggle with DiRT. The handling and performance of each car is distinctive and special. That's what gaming is all about, giving you the experience of the real world on a virtual screen. Not just random mindless clicking.

NO – IT'S NOT!

Social games are simple and lack depth because they're meant to be. Some of them capture the lost era of arcade games that we all grew up playing – it has a bit of sentimental value. That's why games like Farmville were such a hit. They never tried aiming themselves at the same audience that plays Call Of Duty. That's never the point with social gaming.

From a developer's perspective, social gaming is a blessing in disguise. Social networks are transforming the way content is consumed online, and they're the long awaited medium for game developers to tap into beautifully. Social games are the ideal starting point for a young developer who has nothing to lose. The barrier of entry is quite low, game development cycles are short – sometimes just a few months long – and, unlike traditional big-budget games, you don't end up betting your bank balance on an idea that may or may not work. So, social gaming is less risky as well. What's more, with Facebook having over 900 million users, a social game already has a large audience ready to play the game. Social gaming is an important cog in the overall gaming market, more so for a developer who wants to try something without too much risk.

Finally, social gaming, over the past few years, has introduced gaming to a whole new audience of gamers who were never interested in traditional gaming. As far as gaming is concerned, this can only be a good trend – more people busy with some kind of gaming or the other. I rest my case. *